

Tinamous

Order Tinamiformes

Elegant crested tinamou

Eudromia elegans

- ↔ 15–16 in (38–41 cm)
- 📍 S. South America
- ⊗ Locally common

Resembling a large partridge with dark-speckled plumage, this plump ground bird is identified by the slender, forward-curving crest on top of its head. A relatively shy

bird, it usually lives in small to moderately large groups that search dry grassland and woodland for seeds and insects. Both sexes may have several mates. The male incubates the eggs and guards the young, which can feed themselves within minutes of hatching.

Cassowaries and emus

Order Casuariiformes

Southern cassowary

Casuarius casuarius

- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- 📍 New Guinea, NE. Australia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The cassowaries are ostrichlike flightless birds that live in dense, tropical forests. This is the biggest and most powerful, with coarse, bristly black feathers and a large,

hornlike crest. It has naked, bright blue skin on its head and neck, with two dangling red wattles. It feeds mainly on fallen fruit that it finds on the forest floor, and defends itself with a lethally sharp claw on the inner toe of each foot.

Other species

- Emu
Dromaius novaehollandiae » p322

Gamebirds

Order Galliformes

Malleefowl

Leipoa ocellata

- ↔ 24 in (61 cm)
- 📍 W. and S. Australia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The chicken-sized malleefowl is one of a small group of birds that incubate their eggs in mounds of decaying vegetation. The decay process generates the warmth that the

eggs need to develop. The male heaps up a mound of sticks and leaves— 15 ft (4.5 m) across and 5 ft (1.5 m) high—and the female lays her eggs in it. The male then tends the mound for up to 11 weeks, adding more vegetation if it needs more heat, and removing some if it gets too hot. When the young hatch, however, they have to dig their own way out of the mound.

black, white, and chestnut barred feathers



Kiwis

Order Apterygiformes

Great spotted kiwi

Apteryx haastii

- ↔ 26–28 in (65–70 cm)
- 📍 South Island, New Zealand
- ⊗ Vulnerable

This is the largest of five kiwi species. Like all kiwis, it has a big, round body, small head, and slim bill. Pairs defend large territories, sleeping by day in burrows. At

night, they probe for invertebrates using their sense of smell and by detecting vibrations with their bills.

Other species

- North Island brown kiwi
Apteryx mantelli » p357

Rheas

Order Rheiformes

Darwin's rhea

Rhea pennata

- ↔ 35–39 in (90–100 cm)
- 📍 W. and S. South America
- ⊗ Locally common

Rheas are the South American equivalents of the African ostrich. The smaller of two extant species, Darwin's rhea lives in flocks of up to 30 on the grasslands and

mountains of Patagonia feeding on fruit and insects. This flightless bird runs to escape predators, but may also squat under a bush and flatten its body against the ground. It eats shrubs and seeds as well as small vertebrates such as frogs.

Other species

- Greater rhea
Rhea americana » p121

Wild turkey

Meleagris gallopavo

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- 📍 North America
- ⊗ Common

Ancestor to the domestic turkey, this big gamebird has bronze plumage and, in males, a bald blue head and a naked red wattle. Male turkeys are much larger than females and try to mate with as many as possible,

courting them with strutting, fan-tailed displays while giving the characteristic gobbling and booming calls.



Common quail

Coturnix coturnix

- ↔ 7 in (18 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar
- ⊗ Common

This small, streaky brown bird is so secretive that it is rarely seen and is usually detected by the male's

characteristic “whit wit-wit” call. The common quail lives on the ground, preferring to slip into cover rather than fly from danger. Yet it is one of the few gamebirds that makes long migratory flights, with the birds that breed in Europe flying all the way from Africa or India.